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Bob Rosengarden

Drummer/percussionist Bob Rosengarden was born in Elgin, Illinois in 1924. He was attracted to the drums at an early age and used his skills to earn a scholarship to the University of Michigan. After performing with military bands during the mid-40s, he moved to New York and found work with saxophonist Alvy West. His versatility and reading skills helped him find constant work in the studios where he performed on recordings with Duke Ellington, Miles Davis and Gil Evans. Bob played frequently with Benny Goodman, an association that continued into the 1980s. He became an integral part of the orchestra at NBC, later moving to ABC where he led the band for the "Dick Cavett Show" from 1969-74. He returned to a busy performing schedule with "The World's Greatest Jazz Band," "Soprano Summit" and the "New York Jazz Repertory Company." Today he can be found performing at festivals across the country, often with his great friend, bassist Milt Hinton. Bob is a familiar personality at Hamilton and an important part of the jazz events at Fallcoming.

Bob was interviewed by Monk Rowe at Hamilton College on October 6, 1996. Bob's wife Sharon participated briefly in the interview.

MR: We are here today on behalf of the Hamilton College Jazz Archive with drummer/ percussionist Bob Rosengarden, a friend of Hamilton, and you've made how many annual trips here?

BR: Many, many, many, thanks to Milt Fillius.

MR: It's a pleasure to have you again, and last night's concert was—

BR: Wasn't that a good one?

MR: Tops.

BR: You know I'm not being false modesty and any of that kind of stuff. It was one of the better ones. Clark is, Clark Terry has the knack, he's a catalyst and he makes everybody — he kicks everybody in the butt and makes them play, whether they want to or not.

MR: The people watching this didn't get the benefit to see the rehearsal that went into that, but — the five minutes.

BR: The almost-rehearsal you mean.

MR: In five minutes at dinner he says here's what we're going to do, and if it's okay with everybody. And it's an education to watch that.

BR: Well we've all known each other for so long. I mean you know your business, and I know my business. And we know there's a lot of things you don't have to say. Because if you have to say them it's too late.

MR: I read — in *The Grove Dictionary of Jazz*, it says that you started playing drums seriously at twelve.

BR: Yeah.

MR: I mean before you were twelve it was just —

BR: I started playing at five. My mother was a pianist. She played the hell out of "Shine on Harvest Moon," I remember that. And she was a musician. She was a piano player in a silent movie house where my father used to sit there and do a whole bunch of movies, and fell in love with her and they got married and that kind of stuff. And there was always music in my house. We had a piano. During the depression my dad wasn't working very much, and we always had a piano, and I assumed, doesn't everybody — in the middle of the depression — have a Steinway in the living room? And my mother would play the piano and I would sit there with pots and pans and spoons and clunk away. And there was a local drummer, this was in Elgin, Illinois, there was a local drummer who was the high school, Les Gatie — you know I can't remember my children's names but things like that I can remember. And Les Gatie was my first teacher. He showed me how to hold the sticks, and I didn't know any better, I practiced.

MR: You practiced? What a unique idea.

BR: I didn't know you weren't supposed to practice. I just went ahead and practiced. I loved playing, and I never — I've said this before and I'll say it again — I never had to go get a job. Because I don't think of this as a job. I consider myself very fortunate.

MR: You are doing what you love.

BR: Always have.

MR: You were in the service, correct? And did some marching band?

BR: I was in the marching band before that at the University of Michigan, on a scholarship, a music scholarship. And I got drafted out of there, and of course I knew how to do all that stuff and I ended up in the 75th Infantry Division Band, Fort Leonard Wood, Missouri. The old joke is that if they ever give the United States an enema, that's where they're going to — you can edit that out if you want.

MR: No, no.

BR: Yeah. It was really one of the most terrible places in the world. Rolla, Missouri, or Missoura as they say. But I played with, but again, that important thing as you know in your business, you played with people who played better than you do — did. And I learned, you know you learn what not to do and you don't have to be particularly smart you just have to watch. And you had to play all kinds of music which is fine with me.

MR: Well that idea of learning what not to do —

BR: Very important.

MR: We've heard it a number of times.

BR: And I also learned an important lesson, there are only two kinds of music: good music and bad music. So I tried to play as much good music as I possibly could. And worked

my way up, you know, after the war, worked in night clubs, The Copa and Bill Millers of the era, owned by that mythical organization. And met some people who were very helpful and still are. Skitch Henderson for example, who was a conductor, at that time a piano player with Frank Sinatra. And I found myself a job at NBC because Skitch's lady friend, Faye Emerson, who was a wonderful movie star and a funny, bright woman, a beautiful woman, and she was a friend of Mr. Sarnoff which was very helpful. So I found myself on the staff of the radio at the — we called it the National Biscuit Company — but the NBC Broadcasting Company, and every once in a while I'd think, how did I get here? And I played in those days, I made friends with a comedian who I'd always liked, and I still think was one of the greatest comedians of all time, Ernie Kovacs, and Ernie and I became good friends and he always called me "Rosie." I mean I didn't have a first name or a last name, it was Rosie. And he was very good to me and he was going with Edie, his wife, it wasn't his wife then, and I stayed at NBC and he had this wonderful crazy, zany show and I always wondered how it stayed on the air because he would do outrageous things. Sometimes he'd come in totally unprepared and just make it up as he went along. And it was like a quartet or a trio or something like that. And of course I learned, those were my vaudeville days. I learned how/what — somebody fell down — ketch ita boom. That kind of thing.

MR: All the classic percussion.

BR: All the very classic things. And then, in those days the guy came along, Steve Allen, and we're still good friends. Steve came along and they had the Sunday Night Show with a big orchestra, and Skitch was the conductor. I mean it just kind of moved around like that. And then recording sessions. And in that NBC Band were Doc Severinsen of course, he was the other young turk, but there were Will Bradley, a very well known trombone player and band leader at one time; Hymie Shertzer from the old Benny Goodman band; a whole bunch of people in that NBC staff and it was the job of jobs.

MR: When the big band era kind of faded out, a lot of the musicians found a home —

BR: Oh yes, it was the best job. You don't have to travel anymore. You stayed home and the money was good, and you were treated nicely, and if you worked — this was before tapes, so you had to be there live, you know the live shows. And then Carson came along. And Skitch again went right in with that. And he was the band leader on the first Carson show. And that was a wonderful band, it was great band. Doc Severinsen of course was there, all of — Tommy Newsom as a matter of fact was in that band. Hymie Shertzer from Benny Goodman. Clark Terry, Snooky Young, all giants, you know, musical giants. And we saw each other more than we saw our kids, our families, because these were live shows, they were live. And we made them, they were put together with spit and chewing gum, we just floated through.

MR: I was going to ask you when you showed up for a day at work at NBC, did you know what was in store for you that day?

BR: I had no idea and couldn't have cared less. I mean I just showed up. I always came from, in those days, because there weren't that many good musicians, new guys who could play. I always prided myself and it's not false modesty or anything, that I liked the only two kinds of music — good music and bad music. So I didn't mind having to play a polka, it didn't really bother me, I can do it well, and I like had a classical, musical background. So I found myself again slipping and sliding, right back into the NBC Symphony. Because I was one of the new boys. And there was a conductor there at that time by the name of Arturo Toscanini. Dumb luck.

MR: But you were ready.

BR: Oh, yes. I mean how many — you sure as hell better be ready. And the old man couldn't see too far away, you know you had to be right there. So he would look over and he'd make some gesture. And hopefully I'd figure out what it was he wanted me to do or not do. And Carson adopted us. I mean he loved Doc, still involved with it, I still every once in a while hear from John. And again, slipping and sliding we were doing record sessions all the time, you know, every day. And we all saw each other every day in recording. We used to do three record dates a day, and a television show, every day. Seven days a week. It didn't do much for my family life, truthfully. Of course both of my sons are musicians, so I think they just slid into it you know, and my wife was very patient at the time, it didn't bother her I wasn't around much. And we had — the kids just, of course, my dad's a musician and I'm going to do the same thing.

MR: So in effect even though the days of traveling on the road were tough for the family type situations, this was another kind of hardship.

BR: Oh yes well I was away, I mean I worked all day. I had a, usually a 10 o'clock record date or a jingle date in the morning, 10 to 1, they went three hour increments, and then 2 to 5, and then we had a rehearsal that started at 4:30 but Skitch didn't care if we came in late from a recording session, and then after the Carson show was over, because they taped it early, and then there was usually a jingle date or something after. I mean it was every day. It was a wild and wonderful time.

MR: There is a picture, I think Milt Hinton took of you playing the ratchet or something?

BR: That's right.

MR: Anything that came up.

BR: Any percussion sound. Oh that Milt, dear sweet Milt. He's not too well these days unfortunately. But we became very close friends. But those were such wonderful, wonderful days. And then one of the writers on the Carson Show was Dick Cavett. And I had been doing recording sessions. And Harry Belafonte, remember "The Banana Boat

Song?" "Day-Oh." Well I always liked Latin drums and things and bongos and conga drums. So I kind of, since I could read music, and that was never a problem, I never thought about it, I just did it. So I was one of the few quote long hair players, capable of playing that that could also do the other stuff. And I didn't do it because oh I'm going to show you sort of thing, I just did it because you do that. And I used to do, I did all the Belafonte dates, you know, recording sessions. Every once in a while I run into him. It's old home week, it's nice. But I just was slipping and sliding right through that. And then Cavett came along and his manager, who was also Belafonte's manager, knew me from that, said, "Dick is going to have a television show at ABC, would you be interested in being the leader?" And I thought I was going to kiss him on the lips, I said, "Yes!" And I said, "but, I don't have a library, I mean you know." He said, "Well that's not a problem, you know, we'll get one." And in those days you could, there were lots of good arrangers, Tommy Newsom, people like that, who wrote well and fast. And so I can remember giving assignments, you know, I need 14 arrangements yesterday.

MR: Did you give them the song titles?

BR: Oh well I found a gimmick that worked for me. Since Cavett did not have a musical ear, does not have a musical ear, he used to say, I used to kind of begrudge it but I really, it was a compliment. He said, "I don't know anything too much about music, but everybody tells me this band is wonderful." Which is a typical Cavett remark, you know? And we'd all go ahhhh. But it's the best band in town. And I picked anybody I wanted. The job paid a lot of money, it was staff orchestra at ABC. That's when the three networks were American Broadcasting, National Broadcasting and CBS. And I brought in a lot of good players. Walt Mazinski was lead alto player, I had Snooky Young, Jimmy Maxwell, a wonderful trumpet player who kind of gave up playing, he teaches I think. I had — in those days, ABC had very few black people in the band, in the orchestra. And they knew they had to do something, it was a time that the blacks were making comment, you know, waves about this, and the timing was right. So the edict came down from the high, the brass up at ABC, use as many blacks as you can. It was as plain as that. And I said that's fine, I don't care what color they are, as long as they play. And I hired two bass players, Milt Hinton and George Duvivier. And I said to them together, I said — they were very busy recording all the time. I said, "I don't care who shows up, one of you guys has to be there every day. Now you figure out your schedule. No surprises. I don't want to see any strangers. One of you guys has to be there. And if you're half an hour late, just let me know that you're going to be a half an hour late, we'll work it out." And it worked out. They loved it.

MR: What was a typical day, how did it run for that show?

BR: We would tape in the afternoon. When I say afternoon, late afternoon. We'd start usually at 6 o'clock, something like that. Until 7:30. It was an hour show. And then everybody would run to an 8 o'clock or a 9 o'clock record date. It was just, we of course didn't realize that eventually it would end. But all the people I played with last night, you know, we all did this together. It was the best of all possible worlds.

MR: From a logistical standpoint, how did you drummers manage that?

BR: Oh, a whole bunch of us who did recording sessions, finally got smart. I don't know who thought of the idea, Don Lamond was a very busy drummer in those days, there was a guy who has since died, Terry Snyder who was doing the Como show. Very good drummer. Eddie Shaughnessy. Oh there were a whole bunch of us. So what we did is we would get a drum case, each would contribute a drum case with snare drum and stands and sticks and brushes and cymbals. Since I did a lot of Latin work, I would carry my bongos with me in like a little suitcase. And so in each studio, somebody, we got together and decided, okay, I'll have my drum case at RCA Victor, 24th Street. You have yours at Columbia, 30th Street and the jingle houses and so forth, so there was always a drum case there and we had a combination lock with the same combination so that the strangers couldn't come in and borrow things. And as a result, we'd finish the job, and on the Cavett show everything stayed the same, the set stayed the same. We'd finish, get off, grab a cab, go down to the session, walk in, open up the lock, take out the snare drum or whatever you needed and you know it was the best of all possible worlds. I mean I don't think about it anymore, but now that we're talking about it you know it was as good as it sounds.

MR: Was there a method in place at that time where you got royalties for any of that kind of —

BR: It was started. It started, we got a small percentage. But for example if I were to do something that entailed over and above just opening the music and playing it, if I had to create something, in other words they'd say, "We don't know what we want to do" on a jingle they would say that. "We want a certain sound. What have you got?" And then depending on your own make-up you would give to the producer, when you filled out the little withholding slip, you'd put down three doubles, which meant over the, you know, so you would get a bonus like that. But if you contributed something, they didn't object to it either. It was good all-around. And you know it sounds, oh come on you've got to be kidding, but it's true, this is all true.

MR: They're showing some of those Dick Cavett shows.

BR: I know they are.

MR: John Lennon —

BR: VH-1, my wife and I saw — Sharon, what was that show? You can say it out loud.

MR: Well they had John Lennon.

BR: They were done in England, it was one of the other, it was a Beatle, it was —

MR: George Harrison?

BR: George Harrison, yeah. It's the only one on tape. We all had hair.

MR: A lot of hair.

BR: And you only heard the band. Now when we went to England to do the show, I just took the library with me and used an English band, the BBC band, which was a wonderful band. I knew guys that I had known. Our business is very small, everybody knows everybody all over the world. And then I got into the jazz business and started doing jazz festivals, so we all —

MR: Well were you on the show of John Lennon that they used in *Forrest Gump*?

BR: Somebody said that they heard me laughing. Yeah. I was on that show. I am not a shy laugher. And somebody said, somebody called and said, "I heard you last night." I said, "what are you talking about?" "I saw a movie, John Lennon, and there was somebody laughing in the background, and I knew it was you, it was your laugh."

MR: That's great.

BR: Yeah, it was incredible. And then one day, the bubble burst. Where shows changed, I mean everything changes. We didn't like to think it did. The staffs were let go. There were a few shows that were left, the Godfrey show was still on at that time, but they weren't staff jobs where it was a steady job where you got a weekly salary with pensions and all that kind of stuff thank God. And then I found myself in the jazz business, you know, doing jazz festivals and concerts all over the world.

MR: What was the reason for that abrupt change?

BR: Economics.

MR: The studios got together and said this is not —

BR: The efficiency experts. It happened all over the world, came in and said, "Do you realize how much the NBC Symphony is costing us?" Now when the old man Sarnoff was alive, he said, "that's what I want." But Toscannini left and Sarnoff died and they the cost accountants came in. "Why are we spending?" You know, why hire a thirty-seven dollar violinist when we can get one for twelve? You know, that kind of thing.

MR: What did the union have to say about that?

BR: I'm going to not have a comment. The union, by that point was, how can I put it delicately? Lost their guts. They had made so many sweetheart deals with various things, that they really made a terrible mistake. But when Petrillo was alive, the head of, in Chicago, and all that kind of stuff, those days didn't last that long but they were wonderful days as far as the musicians were concerned, because they said this is the way it's going to be. It was "Achtung." But then eventually it really was economics.

MR: Was the technology that was happening, did it have an effect also?

BR: Oh of course.

MR: Electronics and all that.

BR: Oh, yeah. And all the new toys came in and it's funny that you mention the Cavett Show, I got a call several months ago from somebody in California, I didn't know who it was, and they said "I'm calling from Local 47, you know, A F of M, the musicians, and somebody is going to, just bought 26 Cavett shows, they're going to cut them up. They have the right to do that. And there will be some re-run money on that." And I learned many years ago, I still get some re-runs on Sing Alongs, you know, with Mitch? The Thanksgiving Shows, Christmas Shows, they still somewhere in the world they play them. And if I get thirty-seven dollars, it's, you know, dumb luck.

MR: It's nice to see that kind of thing, that somewhere in the world they're playing this and eventually you get your piece of it.

BR: You get a you know, a small amount, but whatever it is, it's thirteen bucks, it's my thirteen dollars.

MR: Didn't you do a thing with Benny Goodman when Igor Stravinsky was around too? What was that like?

BR: It was quite an experience. I think about it every once in a while. Benny was a difficult man to deal with, to work for. He was Jewish but he was Adolph Hitler. He was mean, and different and callous and mean, and played his buns off. He was an inspiration when he played. But he didn't like people. He didn't care. There was a gesture that all of us knew meant go away. Not a nice man. Played better than anybody. And they won't let his memory die. I just did a tour of Japan, a two week tour just recently a few months ago, my wife and I had a great time. Peanuts Hucko was Benny, he became Benny, because Benny had died, and there were lots of Bennies around. Abe Most from California, he does a Benny imitation too; Walt Levinsky does it; a couple of other clarinet players too. Sol Yaged tried too but he wasn't that good a clarinet player.

MR: Well you have to be fairly accomplished.

BR: Oh, yeah, Benny was a wonderful player. Of course he fired me. He fired me many times, I mean he fired everybody. One story I remember he called me, and he had a strange voice on the phone, "Bobby" I mean his voice, "Bobby, this is Benny." And I said, "Yes, I know." He said, "Bobby, tell me something?" True story. And I said, "What is it, Benny?" He says, "Am I mad at you?" And I said, "I beg your pardon?" And he said, "Am I mad at you? I seem to remember that I'm mad at you." I said, "I don't think so, Benny, the last time we worked together was a long time ago, but I don't remember throwing a cymbal at you or you throwing your clarinet at me." He says, "Well, never

mind, can you do—" such-and-such. And then he never called me again. I mean then I did the job, whatever it was, and he just [inaudible]. But, "Bobby, am I mad at you?"

MR: That's funny because you know what that voice reminds me of? It reminds me of the woman who played Benny's mother in the movie they made about him.

BR: God I don't remember that.

MR: Steve Allen played —

BR: Yeah, I remember.

MR: But the woman who played his mother talked just like that.

BR: Well somebody was being funny because somebody talked like, "Bobby," you know and he had these gestures, these strange gestures. He was odd. But he played good, God he played good.

MR: Well he has a whole chapter devoted to him in the *Jazz Anecdotes*.

BR: Oh there are stories that are so popular now. Everybody, I mean every once in a while we go the jazz festivals all over the country which are quite popular, all over the world. On this tour of Japan there were a lot of alumnus of Benny's bands of one time or another, and of course you get a couple of drinks of saki and you sit around and tell Benny Goodman stories, and fall on the floor. It was fun.

MR: Well how did the thing with Igor Stravinsky happen. He wrote a piece?

BR: Well I did a lot of work at Columbia Recording Studio. And Igor Stravinsky had signed to do it and he wrote this piece for Benny, and they needed people who could read music because they didn't want to waste time, and Stravinsky's writing was difficult. It was one of the very few times, if not the only time, that I ever saw Benny uncomfortable. Where he was not in charge. He was second banana. And I mean Doc Severinsen was in that band. We sat there in that band and just relished it. Like your turn in the barrel, Benny. It was, I got a chance to do some recordings like that I'm very proud of. I don't listen to it very often, I think about it every once in a while.

MR: He did something for Woody Herman too I think.

BR: Well Woody wasn't in his class. Woody was a lovely man, but he wasn't in a class with Benny. And there are so many, they still won't let him die. There are still guys going around. But people loved it in Japan, and paid hundreds and hundreds of dollars to come and dance for half an hour or so and then listen to a concert. And Peanuts Hucko was a good clarinet player, he does a good Benny Goodman. I told Peanuts several times, I said, "Peanuts, you're not mean enough to be Benny Goodman." He said, "Yeah, I'll be mean."

MR: Just fire some people for old times sake. Just pretend.

BR: Or he'd go, "Don't play" oh he did that many times. He'd look at a player, for no reason, and he'd look at them and he'd go, "Don't play."

MR: That's about the worst thing you can do I would think, just dismiss you as a player.

BR: Yeah. He couldn't have cared less. He was not a nice man. He played good. Oh, did he play good.

MR: You got in on some Ellington sessions too, right?

BR: Um hum. He did, this was the days of those ping pong recordings, you know the stereo? When stereo really became very big? And Duke did a whole thing with percussion with the big band, with his band. Sam Woodyard was his drummer, was a wonderful drummer. I loved the way he played. I do an imitation. I mean when we do Duke Ellington charts, with any big band if I'm ever working with them, I always do an imitation of Sam Woodyard playing. I'm a good mimic. Because it works. Why would I play Benny Goodman style? It doesn't work. Duke was a lovely, wonderful man. He came on the Cavett show several times and he would use the band. Of course he loved George Duvivier. He kept wanting George to go on the road with him, and George says no way. They were wonderful, golden years.

MR: George was kind of a protégé of Milt, wasn't he?

BR: Well Milt is still this way, he's still the Daddy of them all. He's physically not well, he's got some problems, I understand he's getting — Sharon, how old is Milt now?

SR: 86 or 87.

BR: Yeah, 86 or 87. His wife's not too well. She has got some problems, but they are the nicest people, and I can't think of one nasty or even off thing about Milt, ever. He's always been a gentleman to everybody, kind, generous to a fault. I can go by asking myself, if I called him and said, "Milt you've got to do this thing for me because I need you for such-and-such like that, and I can't pay you anything," he'd say okay. Fortunately it didn't happen very often, but, and he would take off from someplace else to do this, because we were friends.

MR: Well you can measure I think how they're, Milt and Mona are looked upon by when you see them at a festival or something, they can't even get down the hall because so many people just want to be around them.

BR: They are good people. They really are good people. All over the world he's known. Somebody told me that he's getting better.

MR: I heard that.

BR: I'm happy to say. We call every once in a while, you know call them up, and Milt, he wants to play. Physically I don't think he has the energy yet. He may have now, who knows?

MR: Well you're part of "The Trio" which —

BR: Kenny Davern?

MR: Yeah. And —

BR: Wellstood? Yeah. That was a wonderful trio. I didn't even mind not having a bass player. It only would have gotten in the way. I listen to tapes I play in the car when I'm going someplace, and listen to it and I think damn, that's good, that's what we meant. Kenny Davern is a most unusual player. He's not a Benny Goodman freak. He plays like Kenny Davern. He plays like no one else. I think Pee Wee Russell would have been close except that Kenny is a better clarinet player. He is a most unusual player and plays his heart out. There are some moments when we work, we work together quite often, that just are inspiring. One of the bass players that was at NBC in those golden years was Bob Haggart, who is another giant, and doesn't know how to play badly. He can't. And he loves to play. And if I call him, and say we're going to go to Broken Jaw, Nebraska to do such-and-such, you know, "Okay." You know, he likes to play. He might ask who is the piano player.

MR: Good writer too.

BR: Wonderful writer. Wonderful arranger.

MR: It's all part of the "My Inspiration" record.

BR: Oh, yeah. "What's New" the list of [humms]. That kind of stuff.

MR: Who named "The World's Greatest Jazz Band?"

BR: Dick Gibson.

MR: So it wasn't one of the players.

BR: No. Dick Gibson was, is still alive, out in Denver. An impresario. I mean he was a businessman who did very well and he loved Hag and he loved Yank Lawson. Yank was quite a drinker in those days. And so Yank would mumble a lot, and Hag was just Mount Pleasant. And I played in that band at various times. Cliff Leeman was the first drummer. And Cliff did a wonderful job for that band, much better than I did. I imitated him. I did my mimicking. I imitated what he did. But he meant it. And I enjoyed playing with that band because it was good players. Of course I love playing with Hag anyway, he's such a good player. Such a good musician. I don't think it's telling tales out of school, we'd call him "The Fog." I mean he kind of goes away. You know, you'll see him and talk to him and all of a sudden you know he just left, he just left. "Come back!" He comes back. And he laughs at himself about it too. He always looks so serene when he goes away like that, I think to myself, gee I wish I could do that.

MR: You've been a part of so many interesting ensembles, the "New York Repertory."

BR: Yeah. "The Jazz Repertory." Kenny Davern gave them a new — you know, N-Y-J-R, the New York Jazz Repertory. And the minute Kenny saw those initials, he says "The New York Jewish Rowing Club."

MR: He has a kind of a unique sense of humor.

BR: Oh, boy, have you interviewed him?

MR: Yeah.

BR: Then you know.

MR: He has some very strong opinions.

BR: About everything.

MR: Yeah. Even last night he had a strong opinion about a candy machine that didn't give him what he wanted.

BR: Oh yeah, "What do you mean" you know.

MR: He got it. He says "I'm from New York I can get this." And he kicked it.

BR: He's a piece of work. He's one of the last of the Mohicans. He plays like Kenny Davern. No one else. He doesn't play like Pee Wee Russell. He can imitate. He doesn't play like Benny Goodman or Artie Shaw or anybody else. He plays like Kenny Davern. One of a kind. He really is. And I love to play with him because his time is so good. You can go away and come back three days later and the beat is right exactly where it's supposed to be.

MR: You know a lot of the gentlemen that we've talked to that are in their eighties and so forth, like Buddy Tate, they all mentioned that when they were coming up, everyone was striving for an individual sound.

BR: Sure.

MR: And I don't know if that's happening now. I don't want to sound old-fashioned, but—

BR: Well first of all there were many more musicians, there were more jobs so therefore there were more musicians. There aren't that many musicians anymore. Not that many jobs. I feel badly for kids in school here. I'm sure every once in a while someone's going to come up and really turn out to be a player of one kind or another. I don't know where the hell he's going to work. I mean it used to be you can go to a night club, which is a job, you know, to support a family. But not anymore, unless you go to Vegas or a place like gambling casinos where they have shows. All the L.A. guys, the film studios got rid of. You know they are, a lot of them moved to Vegas. Billy Watrous I think just moved back to L.A. Carl Fontana, Frank Rosolino before he died, all those guys, all the L.A. guys. We see each other occasionally at jazz festivals, there are still a few here and there in Arizona and places like that.

MR: So the idea of jazz education in a sense is wonderful but in another sense it's like I don't know where they're going to go with this education except to educate more people.

BR: You said it in a much nicer way than I would have. Because I see it doing this, getting less and less and less and less and less. It's a shame because it's our music, America's popular music. And it's one of the few things that we are respected for all over the world, American jazz. You would have thought that we were the second coming in Japan with the Benny Goodman thing. "Sing Sing Sing" and all that stuff. And it was a good band, it

was a good swinging band and a lot of good players. And I found it inspiring when the people got up and danced and there were some young people there who had no reason to know Benny Goodman, well I guess because it was Western and their parents told them this was the truth, and did reasonably good business, I mean people showed up.

MR: In a social sense that's so interesting because here is music that was popular in the late 30s and the 40s and then we had World War II with these two nations against each other—

BR: And Germany.

MR: And they embraced that.

BR: They just hated us, they didn't hate our music, or at least the governments anyway. Oh everything changes. It's one of the advantages of having funny colored hair, you realize that.

MR: I have to comment on a couple of things last night that are an education in themselves, and one of the things is the use of volume and lack of volume.

BR: Dynamics.

MR: There was some times there where everybody was just leaning close.

BR: That was the whole idea. Less is more. You learn that when you get the funny colored hair.

MR: The funny colored hair.

BR: It's true. It's called music. I listen at home, to my wife's chagrin, I listen to long hair music almost all the time. The only other kind of music I listen to is Brazilian music. I have a soft spot in my head for that. And I got friendly with a lot of the Brazilians — Jobim and Luiz Bonfa. I saw *Black Orpheus* 37 times, you know, and I said oh my God, what is that, and loved it, and became, I was the only gringo who could imitate that.

MR: Right. And knew the difference between the different Latin styles. I mean it's one thing to say well play this Latin. Well there's a lot of —

BR: Well Brazilian is different from Latin. I mean Latin's over here and Brazilian's over here. It's closer akin to jazz, the feeling of, it's in a technical sense, Latin music is generally in even eights [scats]. And Brazilian is [scats]. You know kids in school I tell them see this? It's not this, it's [scats]. And you have to imitate it with your mouth, the sound [scats]. Listen to the Portuguese language, you know, it's very musical. It undulates.

MR: I love that vocalization. It's what Clark does too. You know if he's trying to get a point out to some students —

BR: He'll sing it.

MR: Yeah.

BR: Didn't he play good last night?

MR: Oh, man.

BR: I can't remember him playing this well for a long time. I thought there was a period there where boy are we going to miss him.

MR: Well he put in a year last year, from the looks of his schedule doing his 75th birthday tour, that would have taxed anybody.

BR: Well you want to know something? If he hadn't done it, he would have melted. My wife gets mad at me sometimes because I take jobs. And I know she realizes I do it because I want to play, I love to play. I can't believe people pay me large sums of money for doing simply what I love to do. And the first question I ask is who am I fighting? Who am I playing with? And when I got called to do this, you know Milt Fillius called me and he told me, "I'd like you to do this thing at the school, up at the college," and I'd say, "Great Milt," because we're friends, and, "Who am I fighting?" you know, whose going to be there? He says well Clark, you know, and Johnny Bunch and Bob Haggart, Kenny Davern and Dan Barrett. Wow.

MR: Can't beat it.

BR: That's right. Beats the hell out of working.

MR: How long have you known Milt?

BR: Since I came to New York. I knew who he was because he was with Cab Calloway's band. This was in the 40s.

MR: I meant Milt Fillius, actually.

BR: He didn't know Milt?

MR: No, I'm saying I wonder how long you knew Milt Fillius?

BR: Oh, Milt Fillius. I met him out in Arizona I think at a jazz festival out in Arizona at the Paradise Valley Jazz Party. They have these wonderful parties Don Miller throws. They still go on, they're wonderful. And Milt, well you know him because of the school, but he puts his money where his mouth is. He loves jazz to the point of you know supporting it. And he looks forward to these as much as we do. And I never, he'll ask me, "How do you feel about --" this guy. And I have learned, with my funny colored hair, everybody plays good. Some people play better, but everybody plays good, you know anybody that gets to a certain level. And I'll say, "Why do you want Joe Blow?" He says, "Well we've had him here" and so forth and so on. "Oh I couldn't get this guy and I couldn't get this guy but I could get him. I say, "He's fine." Don't fight it. When he told me that Clark was going to do it, the first question I says was, "How is Clark," you know, "How is he?" He says, "He's fine, he's going to be fine." I had no idea he was this good. Because this is the Clark I remember and loved from the last picture. But Milt Fillius, I wish there were more Milt Filliuses.

MR: To help keep the music happening.

BR: Yeah, he believes in it. He puts his money where his mouth is. I like that. And it's nice that this school, I mean I didn't know about this school before I came up here the first time. And it's like an MGM idea of what a college should look like, it really is. I mean I can see Peter Lawford and you know and Bonita Granville and all those people, you know in the costumes, the sweaters. Lana Turner as a teenager, I can see it here. And of course the weather this weekend has been incredible. I said, "Fillius, you must have friends in high places."

MR: He does. All places he has friends.

BR: He should have. Yeah.

MR: What's in the immediate future for you after you leave here?

BR: I have to ask my wife. Sharon, what am I doing?

SR: You're going to Florida.

BR: Oh, yes, thank you.

MR: With your old friend Skitch.

BR: Scratch Anderson. I'm doing the Florida Pops, Skitch Henderson is the conductor of many pops orchestras. He does the New York Pops and so forth. He's an old friend and has never forgotten it, and I've never forgotten it. When he calls me I say yes. I don't even ask what it is. And he's always been a good guy. He likes music. I never ask how much, because I will do it anyway. And so he's got Walt Levinsky, myself, a bass player, he couldn't get Hag I think so I recommended somebody I knew down there, a young guy that he didn't know. I said this guy plays good, don't worry about it, I'll shepherd him through. And who else? Is that it? I don't think Bucky's there. But we're doing some pops things — Clearwater, St. Pete and Tampa. And I love warm weather anyway, so I'm looking forward to going down there.

MR: Well I'm sure you'll be here same time next year.

BR: I hope so. I sincerely hope so. Can I bring my wife?

MR: I think it's okay. You both have behaved yourself very well.

BR: Well we're not done yet.

MR: Oh, yeah, it's only Saturday afternoon.

BR: Anyway it's nice to talk to you, thank you.

MR: Great pleasure. On behalf of the Hamilton College I thank you for joining us today. Have a good gig tonight.

BR: Thank you. We're going to try. Lord knows we're going to try. Thank you.

SR: [inaudible]

BR: Oh, are we still rolling? Being at the right place at the right time is very important. And my career has always been that way. For most of us who were in the television/radio business, and many, many years ago I was the band leader at the Rainbow Room. The

guy who ran it at that time was a restaurateur named Tony May, a really good restaurant. And somewhere along, he had a partner who in my mind was like Adolph Hitler, I mean he was like "Achtung," everything had to be just so. And eventually they parted company and they lost the Rainbow Room, and then Tony May opened a very elegant Italian restaurant in New York City on Central Park South, a very posh area, San Domenico. The way, in downtown Rome it would be the right one. And every New Years, we're friends, his daughter, who now works for him in the office, I knew her when she was a little girl. Marissa. Sweet little girl. And she talks to me, it makes me sound like I'm 112 years old. "Mr. Rosengarden," and I finally said, "No, Bob. You're old enough now, you can call me Bob." So I would provide a band for him for New Years Eve, a quartet with some good players in New York. And the money is never a problem. And I said, "I can't be there, Tony, because I'm not going to fly up from Florida because I live there in the wintertime." And I've done this for many years. So the other day Marissa called and said, "Bobby, put the New Years Eve thing together." And so I said it's all taken care of, and my erstwhile partner, Tony Sotos who is a wonderful singer and saxophone player is going to take care of it. And then the next day she called again and she says, she was giggling and I said, "What? What's so funny?" She says, "You won't believe this, I need you on October 12," which is another week from now." "Why?" I mean what are you talking about? "My dad," the restaurateur, who has friends in high places, "Is giving a surprise party for Luciano Pavarotti." And I said, "No shit." And she said, "Yes, and we've got to have a group." But I said, "It's like ten days from now or two weeks from now. That October 12 is a very busy night." And fortunately, my partner, who is in Vegas, I'm flying him in and unfortunately I can't be there because I'm in Tampa with the orchestra, with the symphony. And Tony, the boss, says as long as your Tony is going to be there he'll take care of it. And so when I called my partner and I said, "How would you like to do a birthday party for Luciano Pavarotti." And do you know Eddie Monteiro? He plays the synthesizer and an accordion player really, a jazz player, a wonderful musician, so we rounded up — greed conquers all as you know, but I mean my wife is furious because we were invited but we can't be there. You can still go alone, dear. She won't do that.

MR: Oh, man. That's wild.

BR: Is that being at the right place at the right time? And you know there's going to be a lot of wine drinking and you know that he's going to sing. Of course he's going to sing you know. And I already told Eddie Monteiro who is a wonderful piano player, I said, "You'd better get ahold of a bunch of records, because you know he's going to say 'O Sole Mio, D flat'"—boom.

MR: Man, that's pressure.

BR: Derek Smith tells this great story about that do you remember? He got called to do Good Morning America. He got home it was on his answer machine or something. So to accompany him. And he showed up real early and he was like oh my God, no one would give him any music. Finally he says well talk to his manager. It was like three minutes before airtime. And he says oh, yeah, okay. So he gives him the piece and it's like "Deck the Halls" or something. It was a Christmas tune. He was all like, oh, I'm going to have to play something.

BR: It's got to be at least Tosca. Is that the weirdest thing?

MR: Oh man, dumbest thing.

BR: Luciano Pavarotti.